Examining Bihar's Poverty Paradox

"Poverty Amidst Potential: Unraveling Bihar's Paradox"

Introduction

In recent years, Bihar has faced significant challenges in tackling poverty due to factors such as low agricultural productivity, inadequate infrastructure development, limited access to education and healthcare services, and high unemployment rates. We will aim to analyze these underlying factors comprehensively while exploring potential strategies and interventions that might be affecting the state of Bihar and its people. It was also named the 'Bimaru State' of India as it means the poorest state of India.

Educational Infrastructure

The education system of Bihar is at the bottom of the list. The literacy rate of Bihar is at last. Only 22 universities in Bihar, with only 744 colleges means only 7 colleges for 1 lakh students. Imagine your state has the potential of youth but they lack good quality education. Few people got the taste of quality education in both states. Early education must be made mandatory for all people because poor people seem to have no benefit in educating their children. The lack of an educated teaching system and poorly maintained educational institutions is also responsible. Lack of education raises several social problems like domestic violence, poverty, low standard of living, no basic knowledge of land and agriculture, social discrimination, and continuous exploitation at a different level.

Unstable Politics

Good governance and strong political leadership play a vital role in the development of any state. The poor performance of Bihar is also due to caste-based politics. Caste, class, and ethnic division-based politics are still major practices in both states. Most of the national political parties are working on a polarized voting system, the major involves a candidate of their caste who after winning enjoys his tenure forgetting the problems of their people after getting the victory. The back-and-forth of caste-based politics is an ongoing phenomenon in Bihar, where people get elected based on their caste.

3 president rule and more than 8 government changes between 1991 to 2002 shows the political instability of Bihar. When your elected government is busy saving its chair then how can anyone expect them to do any kind of development in their states? This political instability harms economic development.

Unequal Land Distribution

The unequal distribution of land leads to other important social problems like poverty, lack of education, higher class, upper-class discrimination, etc. After independence land related crimes became more common in both states. The lack of finances and education can be due to unequal lands; the kids of zamindars have more power and money to go for education and standards of living than the poor.

The upper crust of Bihar always has the support of bureaucracy, the ruling party has always been controlled by the upper crust of the society. They do not want any changes in it because it will create quality among them. The land was not unequally distributed, but during the colonial period, Charles, Earl Cornwallis's permanent settlement act was introduced in Bihar by an East India company where landlords have to pay fixed tax raised from the land. The tax revenue given to the government is fixed, whether there is a flood, natural disaster or even no revenue generated by the landowner leads to a loss in their land to the zamindars. The farmers and cultivators who are the owner of the land lost it and became the tenant on their land.

Lack of Funds Provided by Center

With such an unstable government, and high corruption rate there is always a lack of funds provided by the center. As governance is not capable of utilizing it for public welfare. It can be easily understood that in some cases their poor governance only manages to utilize the 50% of the budget provided to them. With a new scheme to launch, the middleman and corruption come as a major hurdle. The government of Bihar always fails in developing the infrastructure, education system, and even healthcare facilities.

Civil Services Mentality

We have seen Bihar have more civil services-oriented youth minds. Their view of business is very alarming. As the states and the people see so much poverty, youths have a clear-cut mindset to earn over the table and under the table after getting a government job. This encourages the dowry at very loud and strong levels, we have seen the dowry rate list of the government employees are fixed. The person will get more dowry if he is in the higher govt post.

सत्यमेव जयते

Bihar Public Service Commission

High Population

Bihar does not contribute much to the reduction of population. The fertility rate of Bihar has no significant changes when compared to the national average. Lack of education in rural areas is a major source of the population for Bihar, with the massive population burden on natural resources also increasing. High numbers of the population also give rise to youth unemployment. 25% of population growth has been witnessed in the last decade.

Comparisons to Uttar Pradesh

The crime rate has fallen drastically in UP, as is evident from NCRB statistics, thanks to decisive action taken by the Yogi administration to eliminate mafia and criminal gangs. In contrast, Nitish Kumar has teamed up once again with the very party he has accused of pushing Bihar into darkness. Yogi has freed the police from political interference and given the force a free hand to tackle crime. An empowered police force has, thus, been able to bring down the crime rate in the state. UP is witnessing fast-paced development with a slew of mega infrastructure projects like six and eight-lane highways, bridges, and power plants changing the face of the state.

UP has paid special attention to last-mile connectivity: linking all villages with excellent all-weather roads. Most of Bihar's poverty-encrusted villages lack even potholed roads. At the Global Investors Summit last month, UP received investment proposals worth a whopping Rs 33.5 lakh crore. What's more, all these proposals were spread out quite evenly over the state's

75 districts unlike in the past when almost all investments were made in the western end of UP bordering Delhi. Unlike the tired and worn-out Nitish Kumar, saffron-clad Yogi presents a picture of dynamism. Yogi's crackdown on crime, his no-nonsense image, his stress on Vikas and poverty-eradication, focus on improving healthcare and education, child health, female literacy, and agricultural productivity have created a positive buzz around Uttar Pradesh.
In response to this, the few factories and small enterprises that exist in Bihar pay very low wages. Even educated graduates and post-graduates work in private educational institutions and establishments on salaries as low as Rs 4,000 a month. The job crisis in Bihar is terrible, UP's unemployment rate today is below 4 percent, a fraction of Bihar's rate. Disguised employment, or underemployment, is very low in UP, according to the Centre for Monitoring Indian Economy (CMIE). In Bihar, the police continue to be handmaidens of ruling politicians, many of whom are accused of heinous crimes and patronize crime gangs, Bihar, continues to be a dark spot in the country with potholed roads, dilapidated hospitals and schools, lack of power, and water supply and a general state of decrepitness.

CMIE

Centre for Monitoring Indian Economy

Report

A national MPI (multidimensional poverty index) report by NITI Aayog—India's apex public policy think tank, identified Bihar as containing the highest percentage of the population living in poverty among all states Using UNDP parameters, the report says that with 51.91 percent of population classified as poor, and with the lowest per capita income, Bihar is the worst performer in maternal and child health, housing, water and sanitation, school attendance, electricity, assets and numerous other human development parameters. The perception of perpetual backwardness, caste-based discrimination, and semi-feudal relations of production and distress migration still characterizes Bihar. Growth in Bihar is led by construction and communication, while agriculture grew only by 4.4 percent in the last five years while supporting 70 percent of the workforce. In 2015-16, growth fell to 7.6 percent. Expenditure on public health is deficient—only one district hospital was built between 2012 and 2019. Some argued the growth story was not sustainable since it was based on high public spending on construction.

The World Bank finds Bihar a fast-growing low-income state with inadequate infrastructure, weak governance, low agricultural productivity, low job creation, and high poverty levels, especially among Dalits. Bihar's chronic child malnutrition rate is disturbingly high as shown by successive NFHS surveys. A study in 2013 showed consistent underspending in supplementary nutrition programs under ICDS. It found that service providers were not accountable, while beneficiaries were unaware of their entitlements. Bihar had the highest proportion of under-5 stunting, as per NFHS IV. Although NFHS V has shown a 5.3 percent fall in child malnutrition indicators in Bihar, overall levels remain alarmingly high, with loss of revenue since the separation of Jharkhand as a new state in 2000—Bihar received the debts, population, and agrarian hinterland, while Jharkhand got the cities, minerals, and industries. In addition, Bihar got the fury of natural hazards.

Future Improvements

Bihar can significantly improve in the future through concerted efforts in various sectors. The state should focus on improving its agricultural productivity which is currently held back by outdated farming practices and a lack of access to modern technology. Adopting advanced farming techniques and providing farmers with access to training and financial support can boost this sector which employs a large part of Bihar's population. The state should also focus on enhancing its infrastructure development. Public works projects such as roads, water systems, and power grids can lead to job creation and stimulate economic growth, attracting investment from both within and outside the state. An effective and well-distributed education system remains crucial to Bihar's future development.

By enhancing access to quality education, the state can nurture a well-informed and skilled workforce capable of propelling Bihar towards prosperity. Policies to ensure inclusive education, with a focus on gender and social equity, can address transitional and structural hindrances. Healthcare access must also be improved by building adequate healthcare facilities distributed evenly across urban and rural areas, offering affordable, quality medical care to all residents. Increasing the budget allocation for healthcare, along with a focus on preventive and promotive healthcare, can improve public health substantially. Finally, the state has to work towards lowering its unemployment rate with programs that offer skill development, vocational training, and job links in industries that have high employment potential. Developing these key areas can significantly alleviate poverty in Bihar.

Conclusion

The state of Bihar in India faces significant challenges in tackling poverty, with high levels of poverty, weak governance, inadequate infrastructure, and low agricultural productivity. The education system is underdeveloped, and political instability hampers effective governance. Unequal land distribution, lack of central government funds, and a civil services mindset further contribute to the state's difficulties. To improve its situation, Bihar needs to focus on enhancing

agricultural productivity, infrastructure development, and equitable access to education and healthcare. Addressing unemployment through skill development and targeted investments is crucial for economic growth and poverty reduction. A proactive approach and inclusive policies can help Bihar achieve lasting prosperity and uplift its residents from poverty.